

"BE IN THE WORLD BUT NOT OF THE WORLD" -- THE EVIL OF INERTIA

What is the deeper meaning of the spirit of self-preservation? If the deep mind knows that there is eternal life, why does this same deep mind hold on to life and instinctively fight leaving the physical body? For it is indeed on the same level of inner feeling and knowing that man strives to come into physical life on which he also knows of the eternal life of the spirit. This seems a contradiction.

I shall talk about this very important facet of man's inner life and attempt to give you a deeper understanding of it so that you can utilize it in your search for unification. The longing for physical life expresses the divine spirit surging forward into the void, thereby creating form, matter, material manifestations, and eventually animating these forms and irradiating them with life, consciousness, and divinity.

The divine plan is exactly that: to push the spirit forward, outward, gradually filling the void. As I mentioned before, in the process of this venture, evil comes into existence. The slow penetration of the spirit into the void permits divine attributes to manifest only to a small degree at first. Therefore consciousness is fragmented, the concepts are split, the vision is limited; whence come error, ignorance, fear, which in turn create further evil attitudes. Light meeting darkness initially distorts vision; being is fraught with the threat of nonbeing.

So on the level of your consciousness, you exist in a world torn between the forces of good and the forces of evil. The more the spirit penetrates, the more truth and love transform untruth and fear and hate. The more life penetrates the void, the more immortality becomes an experienced fact.

On the human, seeming level of reality, this process creates a conflict. Man longs for eternal life. He knows eternal life does not exist in the physical body. Yet he frantically strives to maintain life in the physical body. Those religious people who deny the importance of physical life because they sense and inwardly experience the eternal life of the soul, misunderstand and ignore the importance of the plan, of allowing the spirit to infiltrate the void -- finally matter -- and thus spiritualizing all that is.

Yet those who tremble at the thought of physical death because they do not feel the reality of eternal life are equally misled. In my last lecture I spoke of the importance of working through the levels of fear of death and of longing for eternal life. As a next step, it is important to fully grasp how the striving for physical life is not only an expression of this fear. It is, on a deeper level, a valid expression of the great movement of creation, the fulfillment of the plan of salvation.

When this is understood and emotionally experienced, even only occasionally, then the important injunction, "Be in the world, but not of the world," will become very clear. It will lead to an attitude of a joyous will to live in the body, without a trace of fear of physical death. The personality fully realizes that on the more internal levels of infinity and eternality a greater, fuller life exists, which is free from threats -- threats of death, nonbeing, pain, injustice, insecurity, loneliness. The externalized life in the body, in spite of impending physical death, becomes a joyous venture for a greater cause. Physical death itself is seen more and more as a transformation into an original state of fuller existence and more capable well-being.

So a new unity comes into being. The personality knows of the eternal, fuller, deeper life, thus feeling very secure in physical life. Yet physical life is experienced as a deeply meaningful and important undertaking that must never be shirked. Even its difficulties become bearable and meaningful in the understanding of eternal life on the one hand and the purpose and task of physical living on the other. In that way, "Be in the world, but not of the world" will have a new meaning for you. You will know that the world of material manifestation is a temporary manifestation in which you can play an important part and which you need to affirm with all your consciousness and energies, but which you should not ever assume to be your only and ultimate existence.

Do permit the meaning of these words to fully take hold of you. Allow these words to go deeply into you. Even if you are still far from experiencing the reality of eternal life; even if you have not even totally experienced the fear of death and the longing for eternal life; even if you still stand on the threshold of this new phase, it will be very helpful to contemplate and try to grasp this deeper meaning of "Be in the world but not of the world."

This deeper understanding can only come if and when the individual lives with a deep commitment to God to fulfill the task he or she has come to fulfill. You already know that this task must be twofold: personal purification and transformation and giving one's talents, qualifications, energies, and assets over to the greater cause, the plan of salvation according to the will of God. When this commitment is made, eventually everything must fall into place. This may take time because blind spots and a deep unawareness may still persist in spite of this commitment. But time is only an illusory hindrance anyway.

The fuller your commitment is and the more sincerely you mean it and put it into daily practice, the greater your excitement and your joy of living will become; and peace and security will grow accordingly in your soul. Conversely, the more the emphasis of your life is dedicated to the pursuit of selfish ends, the greater your insecurity must be, accompanied by a frightening sense of the meaninglessness of all life. Obviously, this leads to the inevitable vicious circle: if life is meaningless, all you can do is to push selfishly toward at least minor fulfillments, which are divorced from the Christ. And the greater this separation is, the more meaningless all life will appear. And the circle goes on and on.

Still, many of you have made this commitment only halfheartedly. You live with one foot in heaven and one foot in hell, so to speak. Heaven is that part of you in which you sincerely dedicate yourself to the task for God, in which you become part of the great legion, the forces of good. It is heaven because you feel deeply content; your life makes sense; everything is tinged with loveliness, meaning, fascination, joy, and security. But where you hold back and try to strike a bargain, substituting a little self-seeking for doing the will of God, which you deny, you live in hell: hell

because your life appears meaningless, dull, boring, frightening, at loose ends, separate from all things and from creation. To live in heaven means knowing that you are an integral part of creation.

The misconception that dedication of your life to God's greater plan means suffering and pain is still prevalent. If this were not so, the surrender of your will to God would be more complete, less fraught with resistance, and more trusting.

The surrender of your will to God's will, the dedication of your life, your talents and attributes to the great plan, not only make you flourish in all the personal fulfillments of your daily life, but are the key to the unification of your split, where you are still torn between belief and unbelief, trust and fear, hate and love, ignorance and wisdom, separateness and union, death and life eternal.

One of the most important attributes in this struggle is courage. The important role of courage is often underestimated. In fact, people often assume that the spiritual person is weak and meek, which implies that he is without courage. For courage necessitates strength and energy. The spineless are often assumed to be victims of the aggressive, bold ones. Thus, on some irrational level of your emotional perceptions, courage is often associated with evil, while the weak, cowardly person is associated with mildness, gentleness, goodness. Nothing could be further from the truth. I shall attempt to show you now how cowardice is just as evil as active perpetration of evil. Spiritual cowardice not only leads to betrayal of the best, of God, but to as active and potent evil manifestations as does the more obvious aggressive acting out of cruel, self-serving, dishonest malice. It is important to be fully aware of this so as to liberate yourself from the illusion that your weakness, your cowardliness are really not so harmful and perhaps even more spiritual than the fighting spirit of those who risk themselves and their personal advantages by aggressive goodness and positive assertion.

What happens when you are weak, when you do not stand up to evil behavior, when you collude with it and refrain from fighting for the truth? You encourage evil, you sustain the illusion in the person who perpetrates it that it is not "so bad," that it is all right, that it is "smart," and that many are with him. This then also perpetrates the further illusion that by asserting truth, standing up for decency, and exposing evil, you will be isolated, ridiculed, and rejected. In other words, you foster the delusion that in order to be accepted one needs to sell out integrity and decency.

All this happens constantly in human contact and interaction. Such encouragement of evil is a subtle climate, easy to push out of full awareness. Yet around the person who indulges in this kind of negative action and behavior, there is a cloud of guilt, confusion, and an emotional climate of self-rejection. No matter how you try to talk yourself out of self-hate and into self-esteem on theoretical grounds, you will not succeed until you have gained the spiritual courage to be willing to sacrifice acceptance from others -- if indeed you believe that this price has to be paid.

When someone in your presence maligns another, for example, your silence is not goodness, gentleness, peacefulness. Far from it, in a sense it is more destructive and insidiously negative than outright, active maligning. The maligner exposes his evil and thus takes the chance of being rebuked and having to pay the consequences for his evil act. The passive listener cheats by trying to get it both ways: he derives as much negative gratification from the maligning as the active one, without, however, risking any negative consequences and even priding himself that he really did not participate in the act.

Can you see that silent collusion with evil is more abrasive than active evil? Active evil alone could never have led to the crucifixion of Jesus. It required the cooperation of the traitors, the colluders, the silent bystanders who were afraid for their skin and thus allowed evil to -- apparently -- win. But, of course, evil can never really win.

The same is true of the mass murders in totalitarian regimes, such as in Germany before the last war, and other such happenings. The few perpetrators could not have gotten very far if they had not been aided by the silent collusion of those for whom their own skin was more important than truth, decency, honesty, charity, love, empathy -- in short, God, all that God stands for.

This leads to an interesting speculation, my dearest friends, namely that the active principle in distortion, harmful and murderous as it may be, could never by and in itself wreak the same havoc as the passive, receptive principle in distortion. This is why many spiritual teachings say that the lowest quality on the whole scale is not hatred, but inertia. Inertia, on the energy level, is the freezing of the flow of divine energy. The radiant matter of divine influx thickens, hardens, blocks, and deadens. On the level of consciousness, inertia means exactly what I explained before. It includes primary and secondary guilt. The primary guilt is for cooperation with evil, permitting it, conveying one's approval of it, no matter how subtly and indirectly. The secondary guilt lies in pretending and claiming that one is not participating in the evil, and even pretending to be good, when one's cowardice and self-serving gives silent permission to the evil act. This is why Jesus Christ in His life on earth always stressed that the evil-doer is nearer to God than the self-righteous, apparently good person.

Inertia refrains from action for the good. Laziness, non-movement, passivity (in a negative sense) always supports indifference, selfishness, nonparticipation. It promotes stagnation and hinders growth and change in the self and in the environment.

This is why, my friends, you in this community find yourselves in a very active phase. You may sometimes feel that this should be tempered with more silence and receptivity so that more balance be established. But do not forget that there exists an inherent wisdom and purpose in the way the pendulum must swing. In order to take you out of your inertia, which is an ever present temptation, you need to use all the drive and active movement in you even if this means temporarily more activity than receptivity.

In this movement of your soul, you build and create, you change and grow, and your soul becomes accustomed to movement as an enjoyable, life giving, and relaxing manifestation. Inertia is believed to be restful, while activity is believed to be exhausting. This illusion exists as a distortion in the deeper mind. As long as this image prevails, you need to question yourselves when you proclaim more receptivity and quiescence. Is it not an alibi for the temptation to be inert, to not move, to not take effort and risk? Only when you are very sure of this, will the pendulum swing into a new balance. The very overemphasis on activity now is the balance that you need in order to establish real harmony in your soul.

Stagnation and inertia are indeed the greatest evil. They are matter not wanting to be enlivened with the spirit, the spirit of the Eternal, who desires to penetrate the void that is totally stagnant and inert. False receptivity is masked inertia. The more false receptivity exists, the less real

receptivity is possible. The inability to receive love, pleasure, fulfillment, and the compulsion to sabotage fulfillment come from not giving to God. When you give to God, you need to be active, to overcome inertia, to move and do and act, to risk, and sometimes to fight against your own and others' evil. Only then will you feel free from guilt and can therefore truly be receptive to what the universe wants to give to you. The grace of God is everywhere around and within you. It is always there, you are bathed in it. Your inability to receive it makes it appear as though it were unattainable.

Giving to God means to give over to the great plan, to His will, and to dedicate your life to this. This must mean activity and at times even pushing through the inertia that wants to keep you from being active. This active movement may apply to many areas, apart from the obvious resistance within your own growth process. Such active movement is necessary in the smallest details of daily living when you are involved in the noble process of creating a new society. You may have to deal actively with apparently menial, mundane issues. You may have to confront actively the resistance to changes that are so necessary in the process of being, of living according to the principles of divine law. So, my friends, ascertain the exact nature of your inertia and, even more important, how you rationalize it in order to indulge in it.

When you still feel weak, confused, self-rejecting, or unfulfilled in any area, when you are divided within yourself and fluctuate between submission and rebellion, you know quite well that you are divided. You are not yet autonomous. The only way true autonomy can be established is by your total surrender to the will of God. This must include the willingness to be temporarily hurt, rejected, or put at a disadvantage. It must include the courage to risk something or to sacrifice a selfish aim. It also includes the faith that this is truly in your own best interest, even from a very human point of view.

Before closing this message, I would like to talk about and help you with a particular phase on your path. Often you find it so difficult to change a very destructive, very negative attitude or fault even though you have become very aware of it. In spite of this awareness, you find it still difficult to want to change it. For this particular juncture, I have special advice. Actually I suggest two approaches that are both necessary. The first is that you focus with all your intention and acumen on the real effects on yourself and others and the extremely painful consequences to yourself and others of this negative trait. Too often you may be aware of the fact of this negative trait, but you resist the recognition of its effects and consequences. When you fully take cognizance of the effects and consequences, you must experience the pain you inflict on yourself and others and thus be more strongly motivated to want to change. This leads me to the second point. Only by praying for divine assistance and intervention, by turning to Jesus Christ and asking for his personal presence and help, can you influence the involuntary currents and attitudes, can you effect and change them according to the harmonious laws of God.

Your primary attitude in life must become one of dedication to God's will and plan, your giving over in all things and putting Him first. All other things are then the natural effects of this attitude and will be fulfilled accordingly. I know I have said this before, but it needs to be said again and again. If you find yourself unfulfilled in your vocation, if you do not enjoy your work or find it meaningless, if you do not earn enough to give you pleasure and comfort and material security, somewhere within you you are holding out on your surrender to the Creator of all that is. If you lack a relationship and are lonely or if you are sexually troubled, blocked, and unfulfilled; somewhere

within you, you are holding out on giving over to God, His will for you, and to the task you are meant to fulfill. Perhaps it is that you put more emphasis on your profession, your mate, your personal fulfillment than on your task for God, rather than letting these other fulfillments flow as a natural by-product out of your dedication and commitment to your task in which you are meant to serve in the great army fighting for the forces of good. Perhaps you can meditate on these vast issues that fill your universe, that are of real importance in the scheme of all things: the great battle between the forces of good and the forces of evil in the gradual interpenetration of life into the void. When you perceive this vast, universal issue as the key to all other issues, you will begin to put first things first and see your private world in its proper perspective. This will bring a wonderful new balance and harmony into your life that will directly lead you to the faith, the knowledge of the ever living God, and your own individual immortality that alone can still the deep existential longing we were discussing in the last lecture.

Do collect your questions regarding the Scriptures. I would be so happy to answer them so that you understand the world in which you live in yet another way. All these various angles make up the great puzzle -- or what still seems to be a puzzle to you -- until all gaps are filled and you are one in knowledge, perception, feeling, experience, and being.

With this I bless you, my most beloved friends. Let this blessing open your whole being, your heart, and your mind. Experience the Creator in whom you live all the time. Experience the utter safety and joy, the limitless fountain of creative possibilities that this entails. Give to your life a one-pointed direction to fulfill yourself. This can only be done with and through God.

For information to find and participate in Pathwork activities world wide, please write:

The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
Call: 1-800-PATHWORK, or
Visit: www.pathwork.org

The following notices are for your guidance in the use of the Pathwork® name and this lecture material.

Trademark/Service Mark

Pathwork® is a registered service mark owned by The Pathwork Foundation, and may not be used without the express written permission of the Foundation. The Foundation may, in its sole discretion, authorize use of the Pathwork® mark by other organizations or persons, such as affiliate organizations and chapters.

Copyright

The copyright of the Pathwork Guide material is the sole property of The Pathwork Foundation. This lecture may be reproduced, in compliance with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy, but the text may not be altered or abbreviated in any way, nor may the copyright, trademark, service mark, or any other notices be removed. Recipients may be charged the cost of reproduction and distribution only.

Any person or organization using The Pathwork Foundation service mark or copyrighted material is deemed to have agreed to comply with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy. To obtain information or a copy of this policy, please contact the Foundation.